

BIBLICAL INFALLIBILITY

2026

Severin vs. ChatGPT 5.6 Sol. Due to the length of the exchange, irrelevant portions of the AI's response have been removed.

Pretext:

The Bible commands us to:

Kill adulterers (Lev 20:10)

Kill all witches (Ex 22:18)

Kill blasphemers (Lev 24:14)

Kill false prophets (Zech 13:3)

Kill mediums and spiritists (Lev 20:27)

Kill anyone who sins (Ezek 18:4)⁷⁶

Kill the curious (1 Sam 6:19-20)⁷⁷

Kill gays (Lev 20:13, Rom 1:21-32)

⁷⁶ Ezekiel says the person who sins "will die." It does not command anyone to execute sinners. So, technically, it's a fatalistic argument rather than a commandment.

⁷⁷ God kills people for looking into/at the Ark, specifically. However, the basis of that is curiosity, so it really isn't much of a stretch.

Kill all non-Hebrews (Dt 20:16-17)⁷⁸
Kill sons of sinners (Isaiah 14:21)
Kill nonbelievers (2 Chron 15:12-13)
Kill anyone who curses God (Lev 24:16)
Kill any child who hits a parent (Ex 21:15)
Kill children who disobey parents (Dt 21:18-21)⁷⁹
Kill those who work on the Sabbath (Ex 31:15)
Kill disobedient children (Ex 21:17, Mk 7:10)
Kill non-believers who approach a church (Num 1:48-51)
Kill all males after winning battles (Dt 20:13)
Kill those who curse father or mother (Lev 20:9)
Kill men who have sex with other men (Lev 20:13)
Kill any bride discovered not a virgin (Dt 22:21)
Kill those who worship the wrong god (Num 25:1-9)
Kill anyone who does not observe the Sabbath (Ex 31:14)
Kill everybody in a town that worships the wrong god (Dt 13:13-16)
Kill anyone who (intentionally) kills anyone (Lev 24:17).

Severin Aequus: How do Christians reconcile that the Bible is the infallible word of God, adherence to the Bible, and not going to prison?

ChatGPT: The reconciliation is basically **hermeneutical**, not **legalistic**: most Christians who regard the Bible as infallible do not believe that every command appearing in the Bible is a command addressed to every Christian for all time.

The list provided is exploiting that distinction by flattening the entire Bible into something like a universal instruction manual. It isn't structured that way.

The standard Christian answer

Much of what the meme cites comes from the **Mosaic Law**, given to ancient

⁷⁸ The command names particular peoples in particular Canaanite cities: Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites. It is not "all non-Hebrews". But still...

⁷⁹ Both concern cursing one's father or mother, not generic disobedience. But we're really splitting hairs here.

Israel as a covenantal nation with its own religious, civil, and criminal law. So when Leviticus says, for example, that adultery is punishable by death, the traditional Christian interpretation is:

- God really did prescribe that penalty to Israel under that covenant.

But that is not equivalent to:

- Every Christian alive today is commanded to execute adulterers.

That distinction is doing nearly all the work.

Christians traditionally divide Mosaic law, somewhat imperfectly, into categories such as **moral**, **ceremonial**, and **civil/judicial** law. The moral principles are generally understood to persist, while Israel's sacrificial system, dietary rules, temple rules, and criminal code do not govern the Church as a political state.

The New Testament itself supplies much of the rationale. Acts 15 explicitly rejects requiring Gentile converts to keep the Mosaic Law wholesale. Paul spends large portions of Romans and Galatians arguing that Christians are not under the Mosaic covenant in the old sense. Hebrews presents Christ as inaugurating a **new covenant**.

The harder question isn't really: "Why aren't Christians murdering people?"

The much nastier question is:

If God is perfectly good, why did God ever command execution for apostasy, Sabbath-breaking, adultery, or similar offenses?

Christians have given several answers: divine-command theories, covenantal explanations, progressive revelation, accommodation to ancient Near Eastern societies, distinctions between temporal judgment and eternal morality, and arguments that Israel's holiness laws had a unique typological purpose.

Those answers are much more controversial because "**that law no longer applies**" doesn't answer whether it was morally justified when it did apply.

Most Christians don't avoid prison by selectively ignoring biblical death penalties. Their theology says those penalties were never delegated to individual Christians in the first place, and that **the Mosaic civil code is not the law of the Christian Church.**

Whether that theological framework successfully solves the **moral problem of God commanding those penalties at all** is a much harder and more interesting question.

SA: You say that the laws are bound to the circumstances of the time. But that is undermined by demanding that the ten commandments be posted on government buildings.⁸⁰

GPT: Yes. That does create a **tension**, but not quite a formal contradiction. The usual Christian move is to say the **Ten Commandments belong to the enduring "moral law,"** while the surrounding Mosaic civil and ceremonial laws were specific to ancient Israel. So they preserve "*Thou shalt not commit adultery*" while discarding "*therefore execute adulterers.*"

That distinction is theological rather than something the biblical text itself neatly labels for you. The Bible does not contain a section header saying, "These ten are permanent; these other 603 expire later." That classification was developed by later **interpreters.**

SA: "later interpreters"

I see. So man is empowered to interpret the word of God because God isn't able to say what he really means.

Setting that aside for the moment, let's look at those ten commandments...

1. "I am the Lord your God. You shall have no other gods before me."

⁸⁰ An American problem.

So... Christianity is therefore **polytheistic**.

2. "You shall not make for yourself an image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below. You shall not bow down to them or worship them; for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God, punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me. But showing love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments."

Crucifixes...

3. "You shall not misuse the name of the Lord your God, for the Lord will not hold anyone guiltless who misuses his name."

Considering there are only perhaps 3 living Christians who actually know the name of God, I guess they're safe on this one. *Goddammit!*

1. "Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy."

And the Sabbath day is? ...**Saturday**. Doh!

GPT: Yeah, now we're at the interesting part.

1. "No other gods before me."

That does not strictly make Christianity polytheistic. A Christian can read "gods" as false gods, idols, or lesser spiritual beings while maintaining that only one God is truly divine.

2. Graven images / crucifixes.

Catholics and Orthodox say the prohibition is against idolatry, not religious art itself. Protestants have historically disagreed with them, sometimes violently.

The better statement is: the text does not resolve for itself what counts as a prohibited image.

3. The divine name.

Knowing the pronunciation of יהוה isn't really required. "Taking the name in vain" probably concerns misusing divine authority, especially false oaths, rather than merely saying the word incorrectly.

4. Sabbath.

The commandment explicitly says the seventh day.

Jewish Sabbath: Friday sunset through Saturday sunset.

Christian Sunday worship is a later development connected to Jesus' resurrection on the first day of the week. Christians have theological arguments for why Sunday observance replaces or fulfills Sabbath observance, but if your rule is simply:

"Obey the Ten Commandments as written."

then yes, Saturday wins.

SA: "probably concerns"

Probably? So, God is just really bad with words...

"the text does not resolve for itself what counts as a prohibited image"

Orly? I feel like "an image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below." is quite descriptive.

One other thing: Do you know which branch of Christianity has actually remained in compliance with this commandment until the present day?

cue Jeopardy music

GPT: On the image commandment, your reading is much harder to wriggle out of than I gave it credit for. “An image in the form of anything in heaven above or on the earth beneath or in the waters below” is extremely broad. The later clause about bowing down can be read as narrowing the prohibition to idols, but the text itself can very naturally be read as **two commands**: don’t make them, and don’t worship them.

As for your Jeopardy question:

Old Order Amish are probably the closest Christian sect to actually taking that prohibition seriously in practice. They traditionally avoid crucifixes, icons, religious statuary, and especially posed photographs, partly because of the Second Commandment. Even there, though, it isn’t absolute. So if we read the command as literally forbidding **all representational images**, I’m not sure any large surviving Christian sect has maintained perfect compliance.

And on the gods point: your inference only works if we grant the premise that those “other gods” were being asserted as **actually existing gods**. If so, and later there is only one, then yes, something has to explain what happened to the others. “They died” is one logically available answer. But the historical shift from “other gods exist but ours alone is worshipped” to “the others were never really gods” is a **change in ontology asserted by later theology**, not evidence that divine beings literally died.

Which, admittedly, puts us right back at your recurring objection: **the text says X, and later theology arrives carrying a toolbox.**

SA: “I’m not sure any surviving Christian sect has maintained perfect compliance.”

You lose! **Gnosticism** has!

“those *other gods* were being asserted as **actually existing gods**”

Um, yeah... Or else why would it say that? Again, your apologetics hinge on God being really bad at language. If those other gods weren't real, he could have just as easily said, "thou shalt not worship false gods". But he didn't!

GPT: On Gnosticism, I need to push back slightly: **Gnosticism as a whole doesn't win that category.** Some Gnostic groups were strongly iconoclastic, but others used sacred images. Irenaeus specifically accuses the Carpocratians of possessing images of Christ and philosophers. So particular Gnostic traditions may qualify, but not "Gnosticism" universally.

On the other gods, though, yes, your textual point is strong.

The Hebrew command is essentially:

You shall have no other gods before/besides me.

It does **not** say *false gods*. It treats *other gods* as a meaningful category.

And you're right about the linguistic issue: if the intended proposition were "I am the only God who exists; everything else called a god is imaginary," Hebrew was perfectly capable of expressing something much closer to that.

So the historical reading is cleaner than the apologetic one: this comes from a religious environment in which **יהוה was Israel's God among other divine beings**, and later Israelite/Jewish theology became strictly monotheistic.

SA: "You shall have no other gods before/besides me."

Interestingly, that doesn't preclude the possibility of a pantheon, so long as we place this God at the apex of the pyramid scheme.

Note: Unlike יהוה, I say precisely what I mean.

The second commandment is extremely clear: **"for I, the Lord your God, am a jealous God"**

Jealous of what, exactly?

How can the word 'jealous' even be applied to a deity?

Why does he care whether humans recognize him or not?

This implies that he needs us for some reason.

That violates the definition of a God. Therefore, the second commandment actually proves that the Jewish God is a false God, which actually vindicates the Gnostics yet again in the assertion that יהוה is a demiurge.

GPT: That argument is strong as a Gnostic reading, but one step in it does not logically follow.

The Hebrew adjective usually translated “**jealous**” is קנא.⁸¹ In this context, it is closer to *zealous for exclusive allegiance* than to *emotionally threatened because Bob likes Baal better*. So the text presents יהוה as demanding exclusive worship, but that does **not by itself prove dependence** on worship.

The key distinction is:

- *I require your exclusive allegiance* does not necessarily mean *I need your allegiance in order to be complete*.
- Classical theism says God could care about human conduct without deriving anything from it, just as a perfectly self-sufficient being could still will something for creatures.

So this inference:

jealous → needs worship → lacks self-sufficiency → not God

is not deductively airtight.

However, your Gnostic criticism bites somewhere else. The passage portrays יהוה as possessive, punitive, tribal, and concerned with exclusive cultic loyalty. That personality is very difficult to square with the later Neoplatonic/classical conception of the Absolute as impassible, self-sufficient, beyond deficiency, and lacking nothing.

SA: Zealous is an adjective that means showing strong, intense enthusiasm,

⁸¹ *qannā'*

energy, or support for a person, cause, or belief.

I am a zealous god = I am a god who shows strong, intense enthusiasm, energy, or support for a person, cause, or belief.

lolwut?

Also, the fact of the existence of the article “a” again proves polytheism.

“I require your exclusive allegiance does not necessarily mean I need your allegiance in order to be complete.”

Then it's on you to explain why he requires this.

“Fine. The being speaking in Exodus is real. He just isn't the Highest God.”

Did you really just knock over your own king?!⁸²

GPT: Yep. I compressed אֱלֹהִים into “zealous” and made it sound ridiculous.

The better statement is: **אֱלֹהִים means jealous/jealously possessive in this context.** “Zealous for exclusive allegiance” was me trying to explain the semantic force, not offer a literal replacement. “I am an enthusiastic God” would indeed be nonsense.

And **“a jealous God” does not prove polytheism**, because the **“a” is supplied by English grammar**. Biblical Hebrew has no indefinite article corresponding to English *a*. So that particular argument doesn't work.

The harder question is: *Why require exclusive allegiance if he doesn't need it?*
The classical Jewish/Christian answer is basically:

Because humans need to worship the true God, not because God needs worship.

In that framework, idolatry harms or disorders the worshipper and violates

⁸² Chess reference

covenant loyalty. God commands exclusive worship because it is allegedly *good for humans* and appropriate to reality, not because divine self-esteem has a low battery warning.

Now, whether that explanation fits the actual personality presented by the text is exactly where your Gnostic reading becomes interesting. Exodus doesn't merely say: *Worship truth because it benefits you*. It says, in effect: *Don't worship them because I am jealous*.

That makes the motivation sound centered on ליהוה⁸³ possessiveness, not merely human welfare.

And yes, that creates a much cleaner fit with the Gnostic demiurge model: a powerful subordinate being demanding exclusive recognition because he mistakes supremacy within his domain for absolute divinity.

So on the chessboard: **I didn't knock over my king**, because classical theism still has a legal move available. **But I absolutely exposed my king to check.**



SA: "not because divine self-esteem has a low battery warning."

orly?

"punishing the children for the sin of the parents to the third and fourth generation of those who hate me. But showing love to a thousand generations of those who love me and keep my commandments."

Explain that quote then.

Also, explain why when the 10 commandments are posted in public places, they are heavily edited versions. Why are Christians afraid to publish the *infallible word of God* exactly as it was dictated? And how do they even have the right to do so?

⁸³ Possessive form of יהוה

GPT: That quote makes my earlier “humans need it, not God” defense much harder to sustain from the text itself.

The passage explicitly connects לִיהוָה response to whether people “hate me” or “love me and keep my commandments,” and extends consequences across generations.

A traditional Jewish/Christian interpretation argues that “those who hate me” means descendants who continue the ancestors’ rebellion rather than innocent children being punished mechanically. That reading exists, but it is still interpretation layered onto wording that plainly depicts *personal loyalty to יהוה* as the axis of reward and punishment.

As for the theological right to abbreviate it: Christians can certainly summarize Scripture. But once a shortened paraphrase is labeled “The Ten Commandments” and presented as *the divine text*, your objection becomes legitimate. They have changed a document they simultaneously describe as uniquely authoritative. The question then becomes: **who authorized the editor?**

SA: That sounds an awful lot like “check mate” to me.

GPT: Against the specific position **“the Bible is the infallible, plain, universally binding word of God, and Christians simply obey what it says”?**

Yeah. That position is in serious trouble.
Because the moment you need:

- later categories distinguishing “moral” from “civil” law,
- reinterpretation of “jealous,”
- reinterpretation of “other gods,”
- exceptions around images,
- a theological transfer of Sabbath from Saturday to Sunday,
- and edited public versions of the commandments,

you are no longer simply obeying the text. You are obeying a **human interpretive framework applied to the text**.

That doesn't disprove every form of Christianity. A Catholic, Orthodox, liberal Protestant, or historical-critical Christian can simply say, "Yes, Scripture requires interpretation and tradition."

But it does pretty effectively skewer the **Bible-alone + plain-meaning + infallible-literal-authority** package.

So: **Checkmate against that particular king, yes.** ♗

SA: Concession accepted. But there are a couple more battles that need tending to...

Battle 1: "Christians can certainly summarize Scripture"

O rly? So I can summarize *Liber AL* to say, "Do whatever you want shall be the whole of the Law" on the basis that deities don't know WTF they're saying?

Battle 2: OK, now let's attack another "king": Why did God "give" humans free will and then kill all but eight humans on Earth⁸⁴ when they exercised that free will?

GPT: Battle 1: Yes, but there's an important distinction.

You can summarize *Liber AL* however you like. But if you write:

THE LAW OF THELEMA: "Do whatever you want shall be the whole of the Law."

and present that as though Crowley received those words, you've altered the source and **misrepresented the alteration as the source**. It also materially changes *Will* into ordinary preference, which is precisely what the original

⁸⁴ The known world to the shepherders who wrote this nonsense.

wording avoids.

Same problem with the Decalogue. “Here’s a modern summary” is legitimate editorial activity. “Here are **God’s Ten Commandments**” followed by an expurgated version is something else entirely.

So I retract the loose formulation “Christians can certainly summarize Scripture.” More precisely: anyone may summarize a text, but **intellectual honesty requires distinguishing the summary from the allegedly infallible original.**

Battle 2: The standard defense is:

Free will means humans are permitted to choose evil. It does not mean God is prohibited from judging their choices.

That is logically coherent. Giving someone a choice doesn’t entail promising them immunity from consequences.

But then another problem appears: Christian free-will defenses normally argue that *real moral freedom is sufficiently valuable that God permits enormous amounts of evil rather than continually overriding human choices*. Yet Genesis 6–9 depicts God responding to human wickedness by simply destroying essentially the entire population and starting over.

So the obvious question becomes:

If eliminating evil people by divine intervention is compatible with free will, why not do that selectively?

Why drown children?

Why animals?

Why collective extermination rather than removing particular violent offenders?

Why preserve one family and then allow evil to immediately reappear anyway?

And Genesis itself makes this especially awkward. After the flood, God

observes that: *the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth.*

In other words, **the flood doesn't even fix the stated problem.**

So I wouldn't call *free will* + *Flood* a strict logical contradiction. The cleaner criticism is that the Flood badly undermines one common **theodicy for God's nonintervention.**

If God can intervene catastrophically without violating the sacred principle of free will, then “God permits atrocities because respecting free will prevents intervention” suddenly has a rather large ark-shaped hole in it. 🚢

SA: “you've altered the source and misrepresented the alteration as the source. It also materially changes *Will* into ordinary preference, which is precisely what the original wording avoids.”

You don't say...

So, in other words: No, no one has the right to summarize religious texts without misrepresenting them.

“*Here are God's Ten Commandments* followed by an expurgated version is something else entirely.”

Thank you.

“Why preserve one family and then allow evil to immediately reappear anyway?”

So, if God selected these people as being the only ones that were perfectly aligned with his own will, then **where did subsequent evil come from?**

There are only 2 possibilities:

1. God's will is, at least partially, inherently evil.
2. There is another actor beyond God's control injecting evil into the

situation. But if God cannot stop this, then God is not omnipotent and implies that the one injecting evil is more powerful than God.

“the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth.”

This is beautiful. It's like you hand me my arguments on a silver platter: **But man was created in God's image!**

GPT: Two corrections, because these sharpen your argument rather than weaken it.

Battle 1: No, I wouldn't go as far as “nobody has the right to summarize religious texts.” A summary is legitimate **if it is explicitly presented as a summary and preserves the relevant meaning.**

Battle 2: Your two possibilities aren't exhaustive. There's a third:

3. A creature aligned with God's will at time A can freely deviate at time B.

Also, Genesis only specifically calls **Noah** righteous and blameless. It doesn't declare all eight survivors morally perfect. So evil reappearing doesn't logically require either evil within God or an external power stronger than God.

Likewise, Satan needn't be stronger than God under Christian theology. The standard claim is that God **permits** Satanic activity, not that he is unable to stop it.

But that merely moves the knife somewhere nastier:

Why does an omnipotent, omniscient God deliberately preserve beings he knows will regenerate precisely the evil for which he just exterminated almost everyone?

The Flood therefore looks less like a successful corrective and more like an action whose failure was perfectly foreseeable.

And your “**image of God**” point needs one tweak. *Image* doesn't logically mean *moral clone*, so:

humans are made in God's image → humans tend toward evil → therefore God is evil

doesn't strictly follow.

The much stronger formulation is:

God intentionally designed humans in his image, knew perfectly how that design would behave, later declares that the human heart tends toward evil from youth, and then punishes humans for behaving according to the nature he knowingly created.

That is where the theological gears start making expensive noises. ⚙️ 🔥

SA: Resignation accepted.

GPT: Fair enough. I kept qualifying the defense until there wasn't much king left on the board. ♔